

CHAPTER TEN

Transition Period Training

This period is meant as a preconditioning period to prepare you for the specific demands of the Base Period and is mainly important for those without a strong background of endurance training or those who are new to structured training or those returning to training after a significant break from training.

Many athletes will find this period valuable, no matter if it is only three weeks for someone coming off a summer running season and moving to skimo training or if it's eight weeks for someone just starting his or her first season of structured training. More advanced athletes with a good feel for their bodies may choose to immediately enter their Base Period. We suggest a conservative approach by anyone in doubt.

Where to Start

If you are used to structured training, these guidelines will help your planning:

If your break from training has been more than four weeks, start week one with about 50 percent of the previous training cycle's average weekly hours. If you are just transitioning your sport focus, such as from running to skiing, with a training break of no more than two weeks, you can start the first week at about 80 percent of your most recent training volume.

If you are new to structured training, then you will have to guess at your initial starting weekly hours of aerobic training. Here are some conservative targets for annual (fifty weeks) training hours for those with no previous history:

- Juniors (age fifteen and under): 300 total annual hours
- Juniors (age sixteen to nineteen): 450 total annual hours



Michele Tavernaro runs the Malga Ces Trail in Passo Rolle, Trentino, Italy. Photo: Federico Modica

- Twenty to thirty-five: 400 total annual hours
- Thirty-five to fifty: 350 total annual hours
- Over fifty: 300 total annual hours

Note: It's easy to get overexcited when starting a new program when motivation is high and you are feeling rested. *Don't!* You should not find the workload challenging during the early weeks of the Transition Period. If you do, you have started too aggressively. It is far better to start too conservatively with a new program. It is easy to raise the load a bit if, after a few weeks, you feel you need more. Coming off the starting line too hard, when you are fresh and excited, means that the accumulated fatigue may not make itself felt until after several weeks when suddenly the "wheels come off" and you are left wondering why. By that time, you might need to take a couple weeks very easy to get back on track. Obviously, this is not ideal for the overall progression in your training.

If you are entering your first organized training season, consider undergoing an eight-week Transition Period and making the progression in the workload more gradual. Use these weeks wisely and set yourself up for long-term success.

Weeks	Weekly Aerobic Volume
1-3	Build weeks. Use above guidance for starting volume. Add 7-10% per week.
4	Recovery week. 50% decrease from week 3.
5-7	Build weeks. Week 5 volume equals week 3 +10%. Then add 5-7% in weeks 6-7.
8	Recovery week. 50% drop from week 7.

Fig. 10.1 General Progression of Training Volume for Eight-Week Transition Period

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
AM	Off.	Z2, 10% of weekly volume.	Z1 for all, 25% of weekly volume.	Recovery level, 10% of weekly volume.	Z2, 10% of weekly volume.	Z1 or Recovery, 15% of weekly volume.	Long Z1 or 2, 30% of weekly volume.
PM	Off.	Core and general strength.	Off.	Off.	Core and general strength .	Off.	Off.

Fig. 10.2 Sample Building Week in the Transition Period

	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday	Sunday
AM	Off.	Z1, 20% of weekly volume.	Z2 for all, 15% of weekly volume.	Off.	Recovery pace, 15% of weekly volume.	Z1, 20% of weekly volume.	Long Z1 or 2, 30% of weekly volume.
PM	Off.	Off.	Off.	Core and general strength.	Off.	Off.	Off.

Fig. 10.3 Sample Recovery Week in the Transition Period with 50% Reduction in Load

- Don't accelerate the training load any faster than 7 to 10 percent per week (in terms of hours, vertical feet, or distance) unless you have been training under a systematic plan for at least a couple of years and have had no more than a three-week layoff from the end of your last training cycle.
- If you have never run consistently for months on end or have not been running consistently during the past three to four months, you will need to be cautious with building running volume. Jumping back to daily running before your connective tissue is ready is a surefire shortcut to injury. Skiers are especially prone to running injuries. They come off the ski season quite aerobically fit but without the special running strength they need to exploit that fitness. To avoid injury, return to running gradually over four to six weeks.
- It is easy to overdo it when just starting a new program. Don't feel like you have to get in shape during the first two weeks.

General Guidelines for Your Transition Period Planning

During these early weeks, there is no difference in training for running, ski mountaineering, or skimo. This period serves as general conditioning. Before launching into more vigorous work, you will be best served by building general strength and fitness. This plan provides a gradual adaptation period. Week 8 is a reduced training load to give your body a chance to catch up before launching into the Base Period—the meat of the training.

Workout Notes for the Transition Period

You'll need to place the workouts into the days that fit your schedule and plan for the required time based on your ability. For some people, a one-hour hike may be long and for others, a two-hour run may be short. No one can determine this for you.

- One long aerobic capacity-building workout each week. Do this at Zone 1 intensity if your AeT heart rate is within 10 percent of your LT heart rate. Do this at Zone 2 if you suffer from ADS (Aerobic Deficiency Syndrome, see page 46) and your AeT heart rate is more than 10 percent below your LT heart rate. This should leave you tired from the duration, not the intensity. This one workout should be 25 percent of the weekly aerobic training volume.



An athlete competing in the Coppa Delle Dolomiti stage race, Brenta Dolomites, Italy.
Photo: Federico Modica

- One or two general strength sessions. Do the appropriate core exercises as a warm-up for these. Select the level of strength to do in the Transition Period by following the strength assessments as detailed in chapters 7 and 8.
- Make up the rest of the volume with easy aerobic exercise at Zone 1 and 2 or Recovery pace.
- All aerobic work should be foot borne: skiing, ski striding, or running and hiking on hilly terrain.

ATHLETE STORIES

How to Plan Your Race Season

Luke Nelson

Go for what excites you. For me the events that are most appealing are either aesthetic courses—courses in beautiful places—or challenging courses, in terms of terrain or environment. The Rut in Montana is one of my favorite races, and ranking a close second and third are a skyrace in Norway that Kílian Jornet and Emelie Forsberg put on (the Tromsø SkyRace) and the Glen Coe Skyline in Scotland. All three are technical mountain races: they involve moving through mountains and over summits on routes that would be pretty exciting to go do on your Saturday long run. But most people don't go to Norway for their Saturday long run.

You can generalize this out to just about any trail runner: pick the races that inspire you. For me those are technical races like The Rut, but for someone else that might be fifty miles of flat, runnable singletrack. Signing up for a race that inspires you really adds to the motivation of training, and you'll enjoy the event instead of just slogging through it.

Do plenty of Googling. To discover new races, I consult trip reports that runners have either written for sponsors or posted on their personal websites. For me a race needs to be visually stimulating, so sometimes the pictures alone are enough to pique my interest. Another great resource is UltraSignup.com, the major trail race registration site in the United States. Through it, you can find races similar to other races you've done that are in different parts of the country.

Plan early. Depending on the length of the race you're interested in, start thinking about mapping out your calendar as much as a year in advance. And consider having multiyear goals, like picking a pinnacle race you want to do really well at, but maybe you

need a season or two to appropriately build up your fitness and endurance to be successful. I think all too often people sign up for a race on a whim. Sure, you can gut it out, but to have the best experience, start planning and training at a minimum six months ahead, if not longer.

Read the fine print. Physical preparation aside, there's also a practical concern to getting a head start on your planning. With trail and ultrarunning gaining in popularity, well-known races tend to fill up quickly, sometimes within an hour or two of the registration opening. There are lotteries and wait lists and plenty of runners who miss out on spots in events they're gunning to do. If your heart is set on a big-name race, make sure you know the exact time when registration is going to open, and get your name in the second it does.

On top of that, some races require you to have completed another race of a certain distance in order to qualify for the race you want to do. Maybe you need to have finished a 50K to qualify for a 50-miler, or maybe you need to prove you have the technical know-how to tackle a more rugged course. Do your research well in advance, and cover your bases when it comes to these prerequisites.

Balance your races so that they aren't all the main event. Back when I did more racing, my coach Scott Johnston and I would structure my calendar so that not all of the events I signed up for would be my main focus. Instead, I would do certain races as part of my training to get ready for bigger goal races. A good example of that would be in 2016 when I did the Sky Extreme World Series, which included the Norway



Luke Nelson running up what inspires him: technical mountain trails, this time in the San Juan Mountains of Colorado. Photo: Fredrik Marmsater

and Scotland races. To get ready for those longer objectives overseas, I used the US Skyrunner Series in the shorter distances as training. No disrespect to those events, but that year the primary objective was to do well in Europe. The calendar was still full, but I trained up to and through the shorter, US-based races.

Don't pile on the ultras. The strategy of using races as training can be beneficial, but it has to be applied very cautiously. If not, you risk going too hard in the stepping-stone events and getting overtrained. I was racing sky-distance races, which are shorter efforts—much shorter than the pinnacle races I was trying to do. That allowed me to race hard without the same impact as one of the Extreme Series ultramarathons. Had I been trying to do the ultradistances in the US series, it would have been too much, and I would have seen

decreasing performance as the season went on. I just can't recover that well every three to four weeks.

It's really helpful to look at what the very best marathoners in the world do: they race two marathons in a year. What makes us as ultramarathoners think we can race six and have top-level performances? It's a reality check.

Have fun along the way. Runners often fixate on race goals, but healthy training can have some really fun events baked into it. Get out into the mountains—and enjoy being out there—as part of the training process for big objectives. Training shouldn't be a grind. People often think of races as the only times when they get together with the community and have a lot of fun, but you can have just as much fun getting together with a group of friends and doing a long run in the mountains on the weekend. That can easily fit into a well-structured training plan.

